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From the editor-in-chief

Not only did the decisive mandate of Election 2009 come as a pleasant surprise but the profile of the 15th Lok Sabha is also quite refreshing. It will have the largest-ever number of MPs below 40 years of age, 82 to be precise, which is twice as many in the last Lok Sabha. Most of them belong to the Congress party which can be attributed to be part of the Rahul effect. Almost all parties have new young MPs, however, and there seems to be a new realisation that youth brings fresh faces, dynamism, idealism and energy to a jaded polity. There are a number of outstanding achievers among the first-time younger MPs and that can only be a plus.

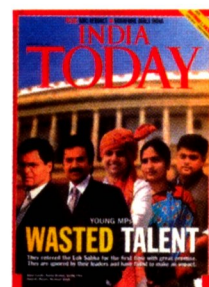
It is also the richest Lok Sabha with an enviable 300 crorepatris, again almost double the 2004 figure. This suggests that politics is now attracting more affluent people which hopefully means there will be less of the spectacle we saw during the trust vote and less corruption in government functioning. Education levels have gone up too; the entire Lok Sabha has only one MP who is illiterate. Added to this changing face of the Lok Sabha is the fact that it has 59 women members, the highest number ever and 10 more than the previous best in the 13th Lok Sabha. Women bring a different perspective to politics and issues and, being part of a male-dominated club, make that extra effort to perform. The trend is a effective rejoinder to the members of the 2004 Lok Sabha who had consistently blocked the Women's Reservation Bill in Parliament.

Our cover story analyses these developments and profiles some of the new faces who will occupy the green leather benches in the Central Hall of Parliament. To get a sense of who these new faces are, what their aspirations are and how they plan to contribute to the legislative process, our correspondents across the country shortlisted those we believe will be making a mark in the next five years and spoke to them and their associates.

Undoubtedly, the new Parliament is a reflection of the new India. That being the case, it is not surprising that the number of MPs with criminal records has gone up from 128 in 2004 to 153 in 2009. Maybe it will take another general election to get rid of this unsavoury trend. All these changes make me hopeful that the new Lok Sabha will see strong debate, fresh ideas and an impetus for change, hopefully all conducted with dignity. There is a great need for the country's faith to be restored in the nerve centre of our democracy. Much damage has been done to this venerable institution by low attendance and many of the antics which have been broadcast live on national television.

The way our elections are conducted is admired across the world. The recent one which lasted for 30 days was done largely peacefully and flawlessly. Our democracy is our most prized possession and the members of Parliament are not only its representatives but also its guardians. Let them never forget that.

(Aroon Purie)



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